

Chapter 131-8

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Being busy with work could, to some extent, ease the longing.

After getting off work, Xu Qingzhu went to the hospital as usual.

It was while driving to the hospital that she noticed her phone kept buzzing.

And outside, it was snowing.

Snowflakes danced and drifted down from the sky, landing on her car windows. The snowfall was quite heavy.

The windshield wipers kept brushing away the falling snow.

Xu Qingzhu felt it was a bit stuffy in the car, so she opened the window just a crack.

Wind and snow drifted into the car through the gap, carrying the chill unique to coastal cities.

The heater was still running in the car, so the snow immediately melted into water droplets as soon as it drifted in.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly thought—if Liang Shi were here, she would definitely ask whether this was for the cold or for the heat.

Xu Qingzhu murmured: "Maybe it's just stuffy."

Being alone was stuffy.

Sitting alone in the car was stuffy.

Even with music playing, it still felt stuffy.

Her phone vibrated frequently. When waiting at a red light at an intersection, Xu Qingzhu picked it up to take a look. Sally had posted many snow scene photos in the group chat. Having not seen snow for so long, she was going crazy playing in the snow.

And Lin Luoxi was photographing Sally.

Sally was catching snow with her bare hands, all ten fingers frozen bright red.

Seeing them having fun, Xu Qingzhu replied: 【What's this? Luring the dog in to slaughter?¹】

Sally: 【On-site slaughter.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Blow you up.jpg】

After casually replying to the messages, Xu Qingzhu continued driving forward.

The cars on the road gradually increased. As dusk approached, the street lights lit up in an instant, illuminating the city's night.

In the distant sky, a shooting star streaked rapidly across.

Watching Sally and Lin Luoxi show off their love daily was nothing new.

She had been watching since university.

But lately, she would think in countless moments—if only Liang Shi were here.

But Liang Shi wasn't here.

So she seemed very lonely.

Xu Qingzhu parked the car in the parking spot at the hospital entrance, still holding a bouquet of flowers she had bought from the flower shop downstairs.

When she got off work, the flower shop was about to close too. Flowers that had been sitting all day were on clearance sale, so she bought a bouquet of sunflowers, planning to replace the baby's breath in the hospital room that was about to wilt.

Her cream-colored long trench coat made her figure look tall and slender. Because of the extremely cold weather, a rosy flush had appeared on her fair face from the cold—at least it saved her from applying blush.

Xu Qingzhu walked into the hospital holding the flowers, attracting quite a few stares along the way.

It was probably rare to see such exceptional looks.

She walked forward as usual, her heart like a pool of still water, calm and undisturbed.

At first, she was walking with her head down, but after nearly bumping into someone, she finally looked up to watch the road.

Just as she was about to reach the entrance of the inpatient ward, she suddenly stopped in her tracks.

A figure came rushing out of the inpatient ward entrance like the wind. She was wearing blue and white striped hospital pajamas, with a light brown trench coat that Xu Qingzhu had left in the hospital room casually thrown over it. It was a bit small, but probably because she had been lying in bed for so long recently, her figure had become even more slender, so it didn't look bulky on her. The color of the coat matched her pupils exceptionally well.

The fluttering white snow seemed to have a rhythm, drifting freely under the street lights.

Blown about by the wind in a wild dance, without any direction.

Xu Qingzhu gripped the sunflowers in her hand tightly.

That figure stopped after rushing a few steps out of the inpatient ward. The two of them stood still simultaneously, gazing at each other across the sea of people.

Glistening hot tears welled up in their eyes.

The flying snowflakes landed on both of their eyelashes, melting instantly.

After a long while, Liang Shi's tears fell. She didn't care about that—she simply opened her arms and called out to Xu Qingzhu in a gentle voice: "Xu Qingzhu."

Xu Qingzhu's feet shifted slightly, terrified that this was only a dream.

She licked her lips and responded in a low voice: "Hmm?"

Liang Shi said: "Come here."

She paused, then said the next sentence in a choked, halting voice: "Don't you want to hug me?"

The sunflowers in Xu Qingzhu's hands fell to the ground in that instant. She ran a few firm steps toward Liang Shi and threw herself directly into Liang Shi's arms.

Liang Shi's arms tightened around her. She bent down slightly, her gentle voice carrying infinite tenderness and attachment, continuing from her previous words:

"I've missed holding you so much, Xu Qingzhu."

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes, tears falling onto her shoulder, her arms hugging tightly around her waist.

"Liang Shi." Xu Qingzhu called her name.

Liang Shi released her and lowered her head to gaze at her.

Liang Shi's voice was very low. Her hand caressed the side of her face, her fingers tracing along her jawline, the corners of her eyes reddened: "Xu Qingzhu, have you not been eating properly again?"

Xu Qingzhu's tears fell onto the back of her hand. "I have been eating."

"But you've gotten thinner." Liang Shi said with heartache.

Xu Qingzhu stared into her eyes, then suddenly closed her eyes. Tears dripped down again, like little pearls.

Liang Shi felt the back of her hand burning. The spot where the tears fell felt like it had been burned by a cigarette, piercingly painful.

"I'm back." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu's clear, cold voice almost merged with the wind and snow. She asked with extraordinary caution: "Is this a dream?"

"No." Liang Shi said. "I'm back. I'm not leaving anymore."

She slowly bent down, while Xu Qingzhu slightly tiptoed.

Their cold lips, carrying a snowflake between them, met in a kiss.

The snow was cold; the lips were warm.

In this moment, they belonged to each other.

Footnotes:

¹ **"Luring the dog in to slaughter"** (把狗騙進來殺): Internet slang used when couples show off their affection publicly, making single people (jokingly called "single dogs" in Chinese internet culture) feel envious or attacked. Xu Qingzhu is playfully accusing Sally and Lin Luoxi of deliberately posting cute couple content to "hurt" single people watching.